

Trust's a Tough Thing to Come By These Days

When Howard Hawks' *The Thing from Another World* premiered to audiences in 1953, it consolidated society's fears of "otherness" and technology in a post-World War II landscape, and its symbolic group dynamics offered paternalistic comfort and resolution with a tone of nationalistic optimism. Three decades later, John Carpenter's remake of *The Thing* focused less on technological and scientific threats toward American civilization and embodied the source material more faithfully with a shapeshifting monster, a stalking anomaly capable of human mimicry, which would have played deftly into the social anxieties unfolding post-Vietnam War. If Hawks' production is a wartime horror about dabbling in scientific hubris and collective action in the face of a common enemy, then Carpenter's is very much a Vietnam War-adjacent exploration of the alienated individual psyche when faced with stalking, stress, assimilation, infection, and isolation – collectively, as a battle for survival. It embraces a dark, distrustful, and fatalist tone that reflects its place in history; cultural and political ideologies associated with Civil Rights, feminism, secularization, deregulation of capitalist pursuits, and the Vietnam War had reached the height of oppositional friction due to developing modes of political discourse¹. Leaders had betrayed followers (Jonestown massacre, Watergate), authority and business had lied to and actively harmed their fellow citizens (Tuskegee Airmen experiments, Agent Orange casualties), prominent harbingers of change had been assassinated (MLK Jr, Robert Kennedy) and the paternalism of American conscription was revealed to be less in the interest of the individual and exclusively in the interest of the state (Vietnam War). The paranoia, distrust, and disillusionment of the individual compounded year after year; for veterans who survived Vietnam, these feelings were magnified by war-time poisoning and trauma and a homecoming of

rejection, very unlike the hero's reception of their WWII veteran fathers. To that end, the horror of John Carpenter's *The Thing* is not in the alien itself as an "other" or symbol of inappropriate science, but in the psyche of men, alienated by trauma inflicted upon them by other men, emotional repression, and a failure to survive when confronted by an oppositional ideology.

Carpenter's film was released in 1982; at this point, nuclear fears were subdued (perhaps becoming part of the backdrop of societal existentialism in the years after the Cuban Missile Crisis), films like *E.T.* and *Close Encounters of the Third Kind* had been released and recontextualized the alien invasion concept as a celebration of technology and curiosity, film censorship was considerably more relaxed in terms of visual expression, and Ronald Reagan's entrance into politics felt like an emotional upswing for a generation reeling from political assassinations, wars, and ideological divisions of culture. The products of social upheaval and shifting discourse did not resemble anything like that of 1953; they sprung forth from an ideological schism between generations, youth pushing back against the monoculture "individualism" of their parents and grandparents. The late 1960s and early 70s ushered in a demand for equity and equality across marginalized groups, and the superficially peaceful "nuclear family" dynamic became an antiquated symbol of repression.

While home and cultural values splintered ideologically, political values split as well; in the early 1970s, Richard Nixon's fraught presidency destabilized American faith in the government's capacity to lead, represent, and protect. While corruption has existed since the dawn of man and plays out differently throughout history, journalism responded with raw truth, announcing assassinations, exposing the nature of the Tuskegee experiment, breaking the Watergate scandal, and providing documented coverage of grave social and political events, like theaters of war, as scenes from Vietnam were televised into the homes of Americans (stoking anti-war sentiment²). By the end of the decade, veterans returning from Vietnam were not held in

high esteem like the soldier heroes of the 1940-50s, did not have the brotherly connection and support of military units of previous wars, and struggled with mental and physical health issues, often failing to reintegrate fully into their previous lives, permanently scarred by exposure to poisons, dehumanizing propaganda, and an inhospitably moist and hot jungle environment that lead to serious physical and mental disease³. Unfortunately, by the early 1980s, America's focus had shifted away from dealing with the psychological consequences of the 1960s-1970s to Reagan's supposed effort in "making America great", and ambiguously threatening films no longer captured the mood of a generation; however, the film is still the product of a generation coming home after an ugly war and failing to integrate, and in the context of hindsight takes on a prescient tone about invasion, consumption, and assimilation that could well have been about the mindless material consumption and moral ills had it come out less than a decade after its release.

Despite its awkward placement in the chronology of history, it is easy to imagine that *The Thing* then takes form as a nationalist-cinema war-time allegory like its predecessor; however, it is a reflection of the lingering subconscious of its audience. This time, the war in question was damaging, soldiers were not reintegrated into society as heroes, and the real evil was man's capacity for betrayal and violence at the expense of his fellow humans. Despite these topical themes, it has elements and archetypes that transcend historical context. There is an anti-hero who sacrifices himself to save humanity, an isolated and inhospitable frontier environment that influences or determines the survival capacity of our protagonists, something Steffen Hantke aptly refers to as "abject geography"⁴, and naturally, there is a monster, leaking or shooting appendages and slimes. It is simultaneously unfamiliar in its "otherness" and familiar in aspects of form, hybridized into a dripping, shivering, squealing tentacled bloody spectacle, triggering an innate revulsion at its contradictory semi-familiarity and excessive viscera. "Gothic's fundamental theme of sins and traumas of the past returning to haunt the present" (Worland, A

Companion to the Horror Film, pp. 284) is also evident; the clear emotional repression of these men implies some past experience that molded their paranoid, distrustful psyches. There is a familiar tribalism in response to this monster, high stress circumstances (sleep deprivation is mentioned more than once), and shadowy, dark lighting and haunting and artificial sounds that create the immersive experience of participating in the emotional affect of some ghastly, sleep-deprived terror. Above all else, the source material – John Campbell’s “Who Goes There?” is, at its core, a horror about stumbling upon the accidental discovery of a mysterious alien other, who uses our innate compulsion to engage in tribalism against us to discreetly assimilate and consume our very humanity from the inside out. It’s perfect content for Carpenter to flesh out, as his work is more broadly preoccupied with symbols and themes of deconstructing authoritative monocultures, loss of identity, consumption by materialism or society, and a general sense of vigilance toward the seemingly every-day or ordinary things that may have fatalist implications for the individual’s sense of self⁵.

Interestingly, Carpenter’s choice to remake the monster as more true to source material made it better suited to symbolically explore the horrors of a post-war era in which the monster is something antithetical to survival: a symbol of consumption, distrust, alienation, poisoning, and betrayal by some larger authority (and its intersection with science). Although the men are scientists, the initial disclosure is not scientific discovery and excitement for the monster itself, but the consequences of the monster’s discovery by some other unwitting research group; the men’s bonds to each other and their survival in this harsh frontier are dubious at best, and in their struggle to maintain the “normalcy” of the research base, are led to this secondary discovery incidentally by the alien itself, whose arrival is heralded by a clumsy gun-wielding stranger chasing a dog. The men instinctively defend the husky from the stranger, and the confusion of trying to figure out his intent without ever questioning the dog’s presence (and, aside from

Blair's suspicions, why would they – Americans and working dog breeds have a history of mutualistic relationships) sets the tone of the film as it becomes a story about heightened, misdirected anxiety, and the men's failure to reconcile and integrate their fears, which isolates them from one another and civilization. In American society, like here, there was a new enemy - not an obvious "other" but a familiar form or figure, a cellular Trojan horse, that inserts itself quietly into the group to devour their individualism or humanity while turning the men against one another. In this film, embracing the repression allows assimilation, obviously not the means to survive an invasion; it has become the invasion itself, now a threat of emotional or ideological consumption by an unknown other who may not have the individual's best interests at heart.

Despite the bloody physical breakdowns as men are assimilated, the monster does very little onscreen (we only see it melt a dog and chomp some hands); its primary purpose is to catalyze a frothing paranoia, explosive violence, and accusatory anxiety that consumes the men with very little direct, active participation of the monster. During the blood test, MacReady has everyone tied to a chair – they cannot escape the monster not because it has them cornered, but because another man, in his paranoia and desperation for survival, has imprisoned his fellow men. He is even called out for killing an innocent man before the blood test, a reminder that paranoid uncertainty, if left unchecked, can be a more powerful monstrous force. It's difficult to discern whether his response to the circumstances is the product of a traumatized mind or overactive imagination, or whether he truly "knows" the alien's motivations and understands that frontier survival is a zero sum game.

The element of body horror is also considerably fleshed out; toward the tail of the Cold War and in the years following the Vietnam War, it doesn't warn against some superhuman perversion of human form, but conjures images reminiscent of the melted, sloughing flesh of chemical warfare victims, a reminder that the old rules of engagement no longer apply and

paranoia toward an enemy's motivations and clandestine means to pursue those motivations is the real horror (and sometimes that enemy is your own government, under the guise of "science"). With Agent Orange and various other herbicides and toxic chemicals having negatively impacted American soldiers and Vietnamese citizens, on top of the discovery of the Tuskegee Airmen syphilis experiments, the bodily disease, abjection, and infection themes reflected heavily on the distrust toward authoritative and capitalist perversions of science, almost ironically bearing the fruit of the seeds planted by the original film's warning tone.

Ultimately, the monster is, yet again, Americans own fear and anxiety vis-à-vis their inability to contextualize the war-time experience in a healthy way; the only monster is repressed national trauma, and even though their survival in the harsh frontier (and their claim to it) depends on collaboration and teamwork, cooperation is difficult to reconcile with blind patriotism and the repression of healthy masculinity (there are no healthy emotional connections or bonds between characters). By the end, it's clear they are not just afraid of one another, but afraid for themselves – they are afraid they might be infected and not know. This theme bears so importantly on the context of the time – the American military had knowingly performed experiments on its own soldiers, Dow Chemical had poisoned a generation and denied culpability, and ideological discourse was extremely polarizing and alienating. Distrust toward authority's dismissal of its inflicted traumas supported a fear of clandestine biological weapons testing, and the men's fear of being "infected" supports this general anxiety toward harboring an unknown agent that may destroy their identity, body, and further alienate them from this small group with its tenuous and distant connection to civilization. Their general emotional state at this point is also similar to a group of soldiers facing an unknown enemy; the rules of engagement did not apply during the Vietnam War, and men who expected to be faced with the same

interplay as the European theater unraveled quickly under psychological pressures and their own “abject geography” in a suffocatingly humid jungle, surrounded by a platoon of strangers.

As much as it is a film about the monster within and human survival, it is also a somber reflection of a generation plagued by the sins of the past – namely, PTSD⁶, in this case characterized by paranoid outbursts, anxious overgeneralizations, and internalization of experience. The film opens with our protagonists already posted at a distant, forbidding latitude, until a confusing interlude prompts mystery, discovery, and fearful projection. Notably, alcohol (and the men’s spatial separation) in the first scenes is quite intentional, as MacReady destroys his chess-playing computer with a glass of scotch. The alcohol motif reoccurs quite frequently; bottles are often conspicuously in frame, indicative of some desperate attempt to distract, cope, or numb instead of build emotional connections with the other men, much like the alienating substance abuse of traumatized veterans. Here our scientists are not pretentious, virtuous archetypes of exploration and discovery, but tired, lonely, frustrated, and emotionally repressed men trying to manage their feelings in a distant frontier.

Like its precursor film, the men are often seen in frame together – they are still technically a team, united by their posting at the base and their core humanness. However, the group dynamic is imbalanced and awkward. There are no women on the base, eliminating any romantic respite, the roles of the men are not as clearly divided by archetypes like “scientist” or “soldier”; personalities are hypermasculine, individualized, grate against one another before the dog and Norwegian even appear, and their “separateness” is palpable enough to create invisible alienation between the characters, comparable to the isolation Vietnam War soldiers experienced in their conscription, tours of duty, and attempted reintegration in the home. This is reflected in compositions that show men together but separated by some depth of field focus or arcs of shadow, and indicated by dialogue peppered with disagreeable bickering; both suggest an

invisible separation or heterogeneity among the group. The group dynamic is also established fairly early – when the group discovers Gary has been assimilated and in the wake of witnessing a terrifying dog-morph, the individual psyche of each man’s fearful imagination overpowers the group dynamics, and the cracks in their bonds instantly destabilize each group member’s perceptions of one another. They cannot agreeably identify one common enemy to band against. Much of the panic and violence within the group could be construed as symptomatic of repressed trauma; their outbursts and destruction are obviously triggered by the unknown shapeshifter, but the persistence and degree of emotional response to it and to each other indicate a heightened stress response and overgeneralized anxiety that identifies anything and everything as enemy, accompanied by loss of sense of self and varying degrees of paranoia, aggression, or fear. Again, we don’t see the alien actually harm the men nearly as much as they harm each other; their detective work reflects their feelings toward the circumstances and each other, and the anxiety builds by virtue of their inability to shed the toxically hypermasculine American violence response and collaborate successfully (perhaps all the alcohol and sleep deprivation are factors as well). When they identify something “wrong” with a member of their team, they react with suspicion, instead of offering concern, community, or assistance. Consequently, the fear of being assimilated consumes them more than the actual alien; the real enemy becomes not the literal alien but the fatalist circumstances and their failure to adapt, cope, or bond.

The emphasis on technology or aspects of science fiction is also considerably diminished in Carpenter’s remake. Science and technology are secondary to the psychological unraveling; it is not about discovery but recovery. Instead of finding the alien and being responsible for its excavation, they merely stumble upon the poor choices of some other base whose curiosity has instigated their demise. Later, they encounter the saucer, this time pre-exposed, as they are not the agents of discovery but merely detectives trying to follow someone else’s steps to uncover

the alien's motivations and movements. Contextually, they (and we) assume it is one of assimilation, based only on clues (which as far as we know, may or may not be accurate, since the emphasis on sleep deprivation, alcohol, and paranoid group dynamics may lend itself to worst-case speculation). In this version, science is allied firmly with the survival of humanity; however, Blair's computer simulation is based on the presupposition that the alien intends to assimilate and conquer, perhaps a projection of man's own constant tribal desires to assimilate and conquer. These assumptions contribute to further division and isolation between members of the group as Blair's analysis indicates that someone in the group is likely infected, and the transmissibility does not bode well for the entirety of the planet. Toward the end, the surviving men discover a make-shift saucer, it becomes clear that maybe we don't objectively understand the motivation of the alien (maybe it wants to get the hell out of here, maybe it wants to reach dense populations); up to this point, they have assumed the stakes are about their survival, with MacReady spearheading every violent effort to hunt down spies in their midst, even suggesting "it wants to stay in the cold until someone else finds it", and ultimately offering himself as the final sacrifice as the barrier between their hostile frontier and human civilization. If observed objectively (that is, outside of narrative elements promoted subjectively by the protagonists), the alien's motivation is ambiguous, and the men's response to it is shaped by their trauma. It's possible, despite MacReady's commitment to vigilance, that the monster has simply existed as an anomaly, but the men's violent reactivity is a consequence of their traumatized imaginations, repressed emotions, hostile environment, and disintegrating group dynamics.

The unease and horror is not entirely attributable to the symbology of a post-war health allegory; it is also blessedly atmospheric in its horror by way of shadowy interplay across frames and spaces, claustrophobic and dark set design and lighting, haunting scoring, a layered, almost child-like shrieking wail as the monster is burned alive, screaming blood, alarms, and a

necessary consequence of the isolated geography and unfriendly climate, the lack of elucidation in regards to the “other’s” motivations, and an implicit pre-existing distance amongst members of the group. It does not just build out the space around the monster though – where Hawks’ film implied horrific dimension in a somewhat abstract form of monster, Carpenters’ forces audiences to face a kind of over-elucidated monster that overwhelms the senses. In not working around the monster, it gives a new kind of monster – a symbol of betrayal, paranoia, and man’s own capacity for monstrosity as he is consumed by pressure and violence against some perceived “other” that feels like a threat to individuality. The ending is also a stark contrast to Hawks’ cautious optimism as we are left to reflect on our own participation in the disastrous discovery and assignment of meaning to the mystery of an ancient alien, and figure out our role in protecting our frontier without destroying ourselves. The negative, bleak ending was poorly received by audiences at the time of its release, and yet quite appropriate for audiences wrapping up thirty years of demonization of conflicting ideologies and repressing identity and emotional experience – perhaps it was a bit too on the nose for audiences to feel comfortable. The alien’s ability to absorb all that it encounters poses a prescient threat; instead of banding together in groups that symbolize heroic or conventional archetypes against a common enemy, the individuals are consumed one by one, their biggest obstacle to survival lurking within their subconscious, ultimately leaving a trail of mystery and goop as their fears catalyze in the form of a shapeshifting alien.

Despite arriving on scene a bit too early or a bit too late, it captured the truth of the burn out. The traumas of the preceding decades were not going away, despite Americans willingness to jump into bed with Reagan’s optimistic promises to make America great, and John Carpenter’s *The Thing* is an emphatic punctuation mark that wraps up the era with a decisive critique of repression, fear of losing oneself either to the repression or expression, and an

exercise in psychology when presented with fatalist circumstance. And at the core of it, it is still a product of national cinema: an exploration of an inhospitable frontier, man's battle to maintain his tenuous claim to some fickle environment, and man's individual choices when given an opportunity to survive. Perhaps its poor reception was a defense mechanism on behalf of Americans not ready to deal with the decay and alienation left behind from years of trauma, and not ready to accept that the history of exploration, discovery, and self-identification were wrought with traumas, repressed in favor of some sanitized propaganda that fails to acknowledge man's sacrifice.

¹ Lowenstein, Adam. *Shocking Representation : Historical Trauma, National Cinema, and the Modern Horror Film*. Columbia University Press, 2005. pp. 112-113.

² Lowenstein, Adam. *Shocking Representation : Historical Trauma, National Cinema, and the Modern Horror Film*. Columbia University Press, 2005. pp. 129.

³ <https://www.va.gov/oaa/pocketcard/m-vietnam.asp>

⁴ Hantke, Stephen. "Science Fiction and Horror in the 1950s". *A Companion to the Horror Film*. Edited by Harry M. Benshoff, Wiley Blackwell, 2017. pp. 256.

⁵ Phillips, Kendall R. *Dark Directions Romero, Craven, Carpenter, and the Modern Horror Film*. Southern Illinois University Press, 2012. pp. 165-166.

⁶ "In the normal, healthy process of mourning, the ego works through the loss of an object by separating itself from the object...In the pathological...the ego refuses to let go of the lost object and instead acts out the loss compulsively, repeating the trauma by turning it inward and enacting the loss as self-torment". Lowenstein, Adam. *Shocking Representation : Historical Trauma, National Cinema, and the Modern Horror Film*. Columbia University Press, 2005. pp. 3-4.

Note: I did not use IMDB as a source, however noticed an interesting bit of supporting trivia (was unable to verify / find a direct source though):

- "While discussing the character of MacReady, [John Carpenter](#) and [Kurt Russell](#) discussed having MacReady be a former Vietnam War helicopter pilot who was involved in some sort of tragedy and since felt disgraced by his service. Because of this, MacReady suffers from PTSD, alcoholism, and severe insomnia. This backstory ultimately did not make it into the finished film, though it explains why MacReady was awake to hear the dogs whining and why he isn't fazed by the grotesque violence. It also adds deeper context to the line "I'm a real light sleeper, Childs.""

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